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Communal chronicle:
The Babri Masjid being
demolished by kar sevaks
on December 6, 1992

royal in question is the Mauryan emperor, Ashoka, and this earliest labelled portraiture of Ashoka comes from a sculpted stupa at Kanganhalli in Karnataka. Surely, the frontal nudity of Ashoka's consort suggests a world that is very different from our own present-day 'civilised' notions of royalty?

Or take the case of cattle which, by a long shot, was a very popular animal food for many millennia in ancient India. This is evident, among other things, from the fact that practically every Harappan civilisation site where animal bones are found, has inevitably yielded cattle bones. And yet, this fondness for beef is something that some Indians find difficult to digest. The major reason must be because they tend to think of themselves as the direct descendants of Harappans. But doesn't the real 'use' of history lie in the ways in which it helps us appreciate and understand the enchantment of times and people that are very different from us? And shouldn't we admire

and appreciate such people, even if they enjoyed food and carnal lives that were different from ours? Until we stop searching for 'our' ways of doing things in antiquity, we cannot freely and meaningfully engage with the enchantment of history.

Expecting people in the past to have been like us can also smother searchers who find 'inconvenient' truths. Think of the fate of Harjot Singh Oberoi who wrote a work in 1994 called *The Construction of Religious Boundaries: Culture, Identity and Diversity in the Sikh Tradition*. He demonstrated historically how an early Sikh tradition, which did not establish distinct religious boundaries, was replaced in the closing decades of the 19th century with a movement that recast that tradition by purging it of its trademark diversity. Oberoi's arguments resulted in an ugly controversy which eventually culminated in his resignation from the Chair of Sikh Studies at the University of British Columbia.

Apart from unleashing intolerance, present sensibilities of this kind can also promote dishonest research.

It is, for instance, unfortunate that despite thousands of metres of soil being excavated from Buddhist religious complexes, faunal records from very few sites are actually mentioned in publications. In Sri

Lanka, faunal remains from two sites, the Sigiriya Vihara and Anuradhapura, have been recorded, but these bones have apparently never been identified. Good historians are supposed to use historical evidence to tell true stories, stories in which 'what' and 'how' explanations are provided. But if the integrity of the evidence itself is compromised, the history written out of it will be a distorted one.

History cannot flourish in an atmosphere which privileges what is congenial and proscribes what is inconvenient. Those who write history, particularly of a polychromatic palimpsest that is India, are not supposed to produce stories which ratify today's predilections of whichever variety—'communal', 'secular', or 'congenial'. This is my one big idea—rescue the past from the pressures and prejudices of today's India.

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